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THE DELHI-NCR WINTER SMOG SURVIVAL PLAYBOOK

2026-27

A family's verified guide to the GRAP stages, the new Delhi Winter Action Plan, clean air at home, and protecting your health from November to February.

DIGITAL EDITION

Verified against CAQM GRAP (29 Sep 2026), the Delhi Winter Action Plan, CPCB AQI and MoHFW/NCDC health advisories. Prices, dates and rules change - always confirm the latest order on caqm.nic.in and cpcb.nic.in.

How to use this playbook

> *You do not need to be a scientist to protect your family this winter. You need the calendar, the four AQI lines, and a handful of habits you can start this week.*

Every year between late October and February, the air over Delhi and the National Capital Region turns into among the worst in the world. This winter is the first time the region enters that season with a fixed, pre-announced plan instead of only emergency orders announced overnight. That change is good news for you: it means you can prepare, not just react.

This playbook is organised the way a family actually uses it. Part 1 explains what is happening and how to read the numbers. Part 2 sets out the rules that will touch your car, your child's school and your office. Part 3 is about your health and your home, including separate guidance for children, the elderly, pregnant women and people with asthma or heart conditions. Part 4 gives you a simple action plan, a week-by-week calendar, checklists and the official apps and helplines to use.

Everything here is drawn from official and primary sources: the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare's air pollution advisories, the Delhi government's winter plan, and the Supreme Court's directions on firecrackers. Where a number or a date could change, it is flagged so you know to check it. This is general information, not medical advice: for any health decision, follow your doctor.

The three lines that change your day

AQI 201 - 'Poor' begins. GRAP Stage I applies. Sensitive people should cut prolonged outdoor effort.

AQI 301 - 'Very Poor' begins. Stage II. Wear an N95 outdoors; keep outdoor activity short.

AQI 401 - 'Severe' begins. Stage III. Older diesel and petrol cars are off the road; younger school classes go hybrid.

AQI 450+ - 'Severe Plus'. Stage IV. Trucks barred, classes VI-IX and XI go hybrid, odd-even becomes possible.

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Part 1 - Understand the season

1. Why this winter is different

> *For the first time, Delhi enters the smog season with a fixed calendar. You get notice - so you can plan commutes, school options and purchases before the air turns.*

Delhi's winter pollution is not a surprise any more. It arrives on schedule, and for years the response was reactive: the air would turn hazardous, and restrictions would appear with little warning. This year, the Delhi government and the CAQM have moved to a proactive framework with fixed dates, running alongside the existing emergency system.

The Delhi Winter Action Plan takes effect from 1 November 2026 and stays in force until 31 January 2027, easing by 28 February 2027 depending on air quality. Separately, the CAQM approved a revised Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP) on 28 September 2026, issued as Direction No. 104 on 29 September. The revised GRAP now carries 48 actions: 25 in Stage I, 8 in Stage II, 10 in Stage III and 5 in Stage IV.

The two systems work together. The winter plan is a fixed calendar of state-level measures. GRAP is the escalator: it tightens as the air worsens, and it can be invoked in advance when forecasts show a stage is likely to be reached. Practically, that means a Stage III order can be announced on a Monday evening and apply from Tuesday morning.

Why the urgency is real: last winter, Delhi went from a moderate day on 13 October 2025 into a long stretch of 26 'Poor' days, 66 'Very Poor' days and 10 'Severe' days, peaking at AQI 461 on 14 December 2025. Early October 2026 already showed the pattern starting - the city's average AQI hit 187 on 4 October, its highest in 83 days. Against that, September 2026 was Delhi's cleanest September in five years, so a good start is no guarantee about the months ahead.

2. What you are actually breathing

> *The Air Quality Index is one number from 0 to 500. In Delhi's winter, PM2.5 almost always decides it - and PM2.5 is small enough to reach deep into your lungs and bloodstream.*

The AQI is a single number computed from eight pollutants, but it is the worst-performing pollutant that sets the value. In Delhi's winter, that pollutant is nearly always PM2.5 - fine particles about thirty times thinner than a human hair. The CPCB sorts the index into six categories, each with its own health meaning.

AQI band	Category	What it means for your health
0 - 50	Good	Minimal impact.
51 - 100	Satisfactory	Minor breathing discomfort for sensitive people.
101 - 200	Moderate	Breathing discomfort for people with lung or heart disease, children and older adults.
201 - 300	Poor	Breathing discomfort on prolonged exposure, even for healthy people; more for those with heart disease.
301 - 400	Very Poor	Respiratory illness on prolonged exposure; pronounced effects for people with lung and heart disease.

AQI band	Category	What it means for your health
401 - 500	Severe	Respiratory impact even on healthy people; serious effects for those with lung or heart disease, even during light activity.

Your two-minute morning habit

Check the current AQI and the GRAP stage before you leave home - use the CPCB app or the SAMEER app (both listed in Section 32).

Treat the AQI like the weather: it decides your mask, your child's commute and whether the purifier runs on high.

The CAQM stage can change overnight, so a ten-second check saves a wasted trip.

3. How the AQI is calculated

> *Eight pollutants feed the index and the worst one wins. That is why a single number can hide a very specific problem - and why local readings beat city averages.*

The National AQI is built from eight pollutants: PM10, PM2.5, nitrogen dioxide, sulphur dioxide, carbon monoxide, ozone, ammonia and lead. A sub-index is calculated for each, and the overall AQI is the worst of those sub-indices. A city can look 'moderate' on the headline while one neighbourhood is far worse, because the reported figure is an average across stations.

There are practical rules built in. The AQI can only be computed if at least three pollutants are monitored, and one of them must be either PM2.5 or PM10. At least 16 hours of data is needed for a sub-index to count. So when a station shows 'insufficient data', it is not clean air - it is an absence of measurement.

The takeaway for a family is simple: use the city number to understand the day, but check the station nearest your home and your child's school on the CPCB or SAMEER app. Exposure is local, and the difference between two parts of the same city can be large.

4. PM2.5 and PM10: the particles that matter

> *PM10 are particles up to 10 microns wide; PM2.5 are up to 2.5 microns. The smaller ones travel deeper and do more harm - and they are the ones your purifier and mask must catch.*

Particulate matter is measured in microns, or micrometres. PM10 covers particles up to 10 microns across - roughly a fraction of the width of a human hair - and includes dust, pollen and mould spores. PM2.5 covers particles up to 2.5 microns, produced mainly by combustion: vehicle exhaust, burning of all kinds, and industrial processes.

The size is the whole story. PM10 mostly lodges in the nose and upper airways, where the body can often clear it. PM2.5 travels past those defences into the deep lung, and the smallest fraction can cross into the bloodstream. That is why PM2.5 is linked to heart attacks, strokes, asthma attacks and reduced lung function, and why it drives Delhi's winter AQI.

For your protection, this is the target. A True HEPA filter is certified to catch at least 99.95 percent of particles at 0.3 microns, which comfortably covers PM2.5. A close-fitting N95 or N99 mask filters the same fine fraction. Anything that only traps 'dust' - a cloth mask, a scarf - is aimed at the wrong particles.

5. Where the pollution comes from

> *There is no single culprit. A CAQM assessment splits winter PM2.5 across five sources, which is exactly why no one measure fixes the air.*

Understanding the sources explains why the rules look the way they do. A CAQM source assessment of winter PM2.5 in the region found that the load is spread across several contributors.

Source	Share of winter PM2.5	What it is
Secondary particulates	27%	Chemicals in the air reacting to form new particles - the largest single slice.
Transport	23%	Vehicle exhaust, especially older diesel and petrol vehicles.
Biomass burning	20%	Crop-residue (stubble) burning plus waste and wood burning.
Dust	15%	Construction and demolition dust, road dust.
Industry	9%	Factories and thermal power.

Weather is the multiplier. As temperatures fall, a layer of cold air sits over the region and traps everything beneath it. Emissions that would disperse in summer instead pile up. That is why October to January is the danger window, and why the winter plan and GRAP concentrate there. What you actually control is your own exposure: the air inside your home, how and when you travel, your vehicle's compliance, and whether you add to the problem by burning waste, leaves or crackers.

6. The science of why winter traps pollution

> *A temperature inversion puts a lid on the city. Warm air sits above cold air, and the pollution that would normally rise and disperse is trapped at ground level.*

In summer, the sun heats the ground and warm air rises, carrying pollutants up and away, and monsoon rain washes the air clean. In winter the opposite happens. The ground cools faster than the air above it, creating a layer of cold, dense air near the surface with warmer air sitting on top - a temperature inversion.

That lid stops vertical mixing. Emissions from traffic, industry, burning and dust accumulate in a shallow layer that everyone breathes. Add still winds and the pollution simply sits there for days. A change of wind direction or a spell of rain is often the only thing that clears it.

This is why the AQI can swing so violently. One windy day can cut readings sharply; two still days can push them back to 'Severe'. It is also why the winter plan and GRAP concentrate on the months when the lid is on, and why a single cracker-heavy night in November can linger for days.

7. Stubble burning: the seasonal wildcard

> *Crop-residue burning in neighbouring states adds a large, seasonal share of the smoke. It is outside Delhi's control, which is why cross-state coordination is part of every winter plan.*

After the paddy harvest, farmers in Punjab, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh burn crop residue to clear fields quickly for the next sowing. The smoke drifts toward Delhi on the prevailing north-westerly winds and adds to the local load, especially through late October and November.

The CAQM's source assessment puts biomass burning at about 20 percent of winter PM2.5, and the Delhi winter plan explicitly calls for coordinated action with neighbouring states to curb crop-residue burning. Authorities across the NCR were asked to finalise their own plans by 10 October 2026.

What this means for you: the worst episodes often coincide with a stubble-burning spike plus a temperature inversion plus Diwali. There is little you can do about the fields, but you can watch for the spike and prepare your home before it arrives.

8. Reading an AQI forecast

> *The stage you wake up to was often decided the evening before. Forecasts from IMD and IITM drive the CAQM's decisions, so a stage can be announced ahead of the air actually breaching the line.*

GRAP is deliberately pre-emptive. The CAQM's sub-committee meets, reviews the current air quality along with the weather and air-quality forecast from the India Meteorological Department and IITM, and decides whether to invoke or lift a stage. If a higher AQI is forecast to sustain, the stage can be invoked in advance; if conditions are expected to improve, it can be lifted.

That is why an order can appear on a Monday evening and apply from Tuesday morning, and why a stage can be in force even though the day's reading has not crossed the threshold yet.

Practical habit: check both the current AQI and the CAQM's stage each morning. The current number tells you today's exposure; the stage tells you which rules are active.

9. Air quality beyond Delhi: a wider look

> *Delhi is the worst-known case, but winter pollution is a north-India problem. If you travel, or have family elsewhere, the same habits travel with you.*

Delhi-NCR gets the attention because its winter readings are the highest and its rules the most formalised, but it is not alone. Cities across the Indo-Gangetic plain - from Punjab and Haryana through Uttar Pradesh and Bihar to West Bengal - share the same winter conditions: cold, still air that traps emissions, plus a dust and burning load that crosses state lines.

The Central Pollution Control Board runs the AQI network nationally, and the same six categories and the same health advice apply everywhere. If you have family in another city, the principles hold: check the local station, protect the vulnerable, keep indoor air clean, and wear a proper mask when levels are high.

Even cities that are cleaner in winter have bad days. The habit of checking the AQI before you decide how to travel and whether to exercise is worth keeping all year, wherever you are.

10. The money behind the clean-air effort

> *Public money and enforcement matter as much as any personal habit - and the record shows the gap between announcing a measure and making it work.*

Delhi's clean-air funding has lagged its plans. Official figures show Delhi had used only a fraction of the central National Clean Air Programme funds released to it - reported at about 28 percent by late 2023, and about 17 percent in a later government reply. A seven-year programme of roughly Rs 8,300 crore was announced, split between a World Bank loan and state funds, but it depends on financing that had not been approved as of October 2026.

Enforcement is the other half. The CAQM reported issuing closure orders to 1,831 units by 17 September 2026, with many later cleared to resume after compliance. Delhi surveyed 11,271 industrial units between December 2025 and 26 September 2026 and closed or sealed 2,283 of them.

Why this matters to a household: the rules you read about are only as good as their enforcement, and enforcement has historically been the weak point. That is the strongest argument for doing what you can inside your own four walls, rather than waiting for the air to be fixed for you.

11. A short history: how the winter rules evolved

> *The system you are dealing with was built over several winters. Knowing how it evolved explains why it now works the way it does.*

The Graded Response Action Plan dates to 2016-17, when it was run by the Supreme Court-appointed Environment Pollution (Prevention and Control) Authority. The CAQM itself was created by a 2021 Act, after years of disputes between Delhi and neighbouring states over who was responsible for the region's air.

Since then the schedule has been revised most years - the 2026 revision is the latest. What has changed this year is the emphasis: from a purely reactive, AQI-triggered system to a hybrid, where a fixed state calendar runs alongside the forecast-based escalator.

Understanding this helps you read the news. When you see a 'GRAP Stage III invoked' headline, it means the CAQM sub-committee has acted on a forecast. When you see the 'winter action plan', it means the fixed calendar of state measures. They are different instruments, and both apply to you.

12. The month-by-month shape of winter

> *The season has a rhythm. October is the warning, November builds, December and January are the peak, and February is the slow release.*

Knowing the shape of the season helps you time everything from a purifier purchase to a family trip. The pattern below is drawn from recent winters and the CAQM's own analysis of how quickly conditions change.

Month	What to expect	What to do
October	Air starts to slip as monsoon ends and stubble burning begins. Early October 2026 already hit AQI 187.	Service the purifier, check the car, stock masks, save the apps.
November	The plan's fixed measures start on 1 November. Diwali (8 Nov) can spike the air sharply.	Expect hybrid school days and the vehicle entry ban; plan Diwali week indoors.
December	Historically the worst month - last winter peaked at 461 on 14 December. The full construction ban runs 10 Dec to 20 Jan.	Run the purifier on high; minimise travel; keep medicines stocked.
January	Cold and still. Stage III and IV orders are most likely. Schools may shift to online.	Watch the daily stage; use the hybrid school option; avoid outdoor exercise.
February	The plan begins to ease, but bad spells still happen until the end of the month.	Do not relax too early - keep checking the stage until the air clears.

Part 2 - The rules that will affect your family

13. GRAP decoded: the four stages

> *GRAP is the escalator. Stage I starts at AQI 201 and each stage adds to the one before, so Stage IV carries every restriction below it.*

The Graded Response Action Plan is run by the CAQM across the whole of Delhi-NCR. It links AQI bands to specific restrictions and can be invoked ahead of the air actually reaching a threshold, based on forecasts from the India Meteorological Department and IITM. Here is what each stage brings.

Stage (AQI in Delhi)	Category	What gets triggered
Stage I (201-300)	Poor	Strict dust control at construction sites; mechanised road sweeping and water sprinkling; ban on open burning of waste and biomass; strict PUC enforcement. From 2026, curbs on diesel generator sets and older (BS-IV and below) inter-city buses begin here rather than at Stage II.
Stage II (301-400)	Very Poor	Everything above, plus higher parking charges, intensified sweeping and sprinkling, restrictions on diesel generator sets, and staggered office timings in Delhi and the districts of Gurugram, Faridabad, Ghaziabad and Gautam Buddh Nagar.
Stage III (401-450)	Severe	Everything above, plus a ban on non-essential construction and demolition categories; a ban on BS-III petrol and BS-IV diesel four-wheelers (now including Sonipat); mandatory hybrid classes up to Class V; government may run offices at 50% strength.
Stage IV (450+)	Severe Plus	Everything above, plus a ban on truck entry into Delhi except for essential goods and services; hybrid classes extended to Classes VI-IX and XI; states may close colleges and non-emergency commercial activity and may consider the odd-even scheme.

Two things are worth repeating. First, restrictions are cumulative: when Stage III is active, everything in Stages I and II applies too. Second, the trigger is a forecast as much as a reading, so a stage can begin before the AQI actually crosses the line - and it can be lifted the moment conditions ease.

14. The GRAP citizen charter: your part of the deal

> *GRAP is not only about what the government does. The revised schedule's citizen charter has grown to 34 actions - the everyday steps residents are asked to take.*

The revised GRAP expanded its citizen charter from 22 actions to 34, and most of them are practical things a household can do. They are worth reading once, because they double as a sensible default routine for the whole season.

- Use public transport and minimise personal vehicle use; take a less congested route even if it is slightly longer.
- Ensure proper parking and lane driving, and keep footpaths clear.
- Replace your vehicle's air filters at the recommended intervals.
- Avoid dust-generating construction work during October to January.
- Clean kitchen chimney filters regularly.
- Avoid outdoor smoke-generating cooking and heating in residential areas and public spaces.

- Avoid accumulating and burning solid waste and biomass.
- Work from home if your position allows it.
- Report polluting activities through the 311 app, the Green Delhi app or the SAMEER app.

Why the charter matters

Government measures cut emissions at the source; the charter cuts them at the household level. Together they are the only way a city of this size moves the number.

Reporting matters too: a complaint with a photo is logged and tracked to a department, and hotspots are inspected weekly.

15. The Delhi Winter Action Plan 2026-27: the fixed calendar

These measures no longer wait for the air to fail. They start on set dates and run to the end of January, with the heaviest construction ban in December and January.

The plan also scales up enforcement. Continuous monitoring stations rise from 47 to 60, with 334 enforcement teams (256 ward-level and 78 from the Delhi Pollution Control Committee), an AI-enabled command-and-control centre, weekly inspections of pollution hotspots, and a daily evening AQI bulletin. Office timings were set with MCD offices running 8:30 am to 5 pm and Delhi government offices 10 am to 6:30 pm.

On the ground, the state has also been acting against polluting units: between December 2025 and 26 September 2026, 11,271 industrial units were surveyed and 2,283 polluting units were closed or sealed. Dust-generating construction sites are monitored through a Dust Portal with cameras and sensors, and major sites must run anti-smog guns or mist-suppression systems.

From	Measure
1 Oct 2026 (live)	'No PUCC, No Fuel' at all 500 fuel stations in Delhi fitted with number-plate cameras. Vehicles without a valid Pollution Under Control Certificate - and end-of-life vehicles - are refused fuel.
1 Nov 2026	Vehicles registered outside Delhi that do not meet BS-VI emission standards are barred from entering the city (CNG and electric vehicles exempt).
1 Nov 2026	Dust-generating demolition and outdoor civil construction restricted.
1 Nov 2026 - 31 Jan 2027	Up to 50% work-from-home and staggered office timings for government and private offices (essential services exempt).
1 Nov 2026 - 31 Jan 2027	Parking charges at authorised sites doubled (Delhi Metro facilities exempt).
10 Dec 2026 - 20 Jan 2027	Complete ban on construction and demolition activity, except urgent government and emergency works.
Runs to 28 Feb 2027	The whole plan eases gradually depending on air quality.

16. The 2026 CAQM directions that change this year

Five CAQM directions shape this winter. Two of them - the 'no PUC, no fuel' rule and the revised GRAP - are the ones most likely to touch you directly.

If you run a business, the practical headline is that the rules on dust and on industrial particulate limits now reach further than before - including sites and units outside municipal boundaries. If you drive, Section 11 is your checklist.

Direction	What it requires	When it applies
No. 104 (29 Sep 2026)	The revised GRAP schedule: 48 actions across four stages. Diesel genset and BS-IV inter-city bus curbs move to Stage I; the Stage III vehicle ban now covers Sonipat; the goods-vehicle exemption is removed in Stages III and IV; construction-dust rules now reach sites outside municipal limits.	Immediate
No. 101 (15 May 2026)	No fuel at any fuel station in the NCR for a vehicle without a valid Pollution Under Control Certificate, identified by number-plate cameras. Medical, law-and-order and disaster-response vehicles excepted.	1 Oct 2026
No. 98 (20 Feb 2026)	A particulate limit of 50 milligrams per normal cubic metre for 17 categories of highly polluting industry.	1 Aug 2026 (large/medium), 1 Oct 2026 (the rest)
No. 103 (19 Aug 2026)	Stone crushers must meet dust conditions, register on a monitoring portal, install video surveillance and PM2.5/PM10 sensors, and provide wheel washing.	1 Nov 2026
No. 100 (15 May 2026)	Only electric three-wheelers may be registered.	Delhi from 1 Jan 2027

17. Your car this winter: the compliance checklist

> *The single most useful habit is knowing your vehicle's fuel type, BS stage and age. That, plus a valid PUC certificate, decides whether you can legally drive on any given day.*

Penalties have been rising: fines, impoundment at major junctions, and in the worst cases permanent deregistration for out-of-age diesel vehicles. The one habit that avoids all of it is a daily check of the CAQM stage before your commute.

1. **Keep a valid PUC certificate.** Since 1 October 2026, fuel stations across the NCR will not sell fuel to a vehicle without one. There are no exceptions for private cars.
2. **Know your vehicle's age.** End-of-life vehicles - 15 years for petrol, 10 years for diesel - are refused fuel and face deregistration. Treat these as hard limits.
3. **If your vehicle is registered outside Delhi and is below BS-VI**, it cannot enter the city from 1 November 2026 to 31 January 2027. CNG and electric vehicles are exempt.
4. **Track the GRAP stage each morning in winter.** At Stage III, BS-III petrol and BS-IV diesel four-wheelers are banned in Delhi and in Gurugram, Faridabad, Ghaziabad, Gautam Buddh Nagar and Sonipat.
5. **Expect odd-even only under Stage IV.** It is not in continuous operation in 2026, but it remains an available tool when AQI stays above 450, typically with about 48 hours' notice.

GRAP stage active	Can I drive my car in Delhi-NCR?
Stage I - II	Yes, with a valid PUC certificate. Older end-of-life and out-of-state sub-BS-VI vehicles face their standing bans.
Stage III	BS-III petrol and BS-IV diesel four-wheelers: no. BS-VI vehicles: yes.
Stage IV	All non-essential diesel banned; inter-state truck entry restricted; odd-even possible with notice. Metro and e-rickshaws are the safe fallback.

18. Two-wheeler riders, autos and cabs

> *Riders are among the most exposed people on the road, because they sit directly in the exhaust plume with no cabin to filter it. Small changes cut the dose sharply.*

- Wear a close-fitting N95 or N99, and wear a full-face helmet with the visor down - it keeps grit and particles off your face and eyes.
- Avoid the peak-exposure windows where you can: early morning and late evening are usually the worst.
- Keep your own two-wheeler serviced and its PUC current; a badly tuned engine emits more and puts you behind a dirtier plume.
- On long rides, prefer routes away from heavy truck and construction traffic.
- Auto and cab users: ask for the air-conditioning on recirculate so the cabin is not drawing in outside air, and keep windows up in the worst stretches.
- After a ride, wash your face and hands and change out of the outer layer you wore on the road.

19. If you run a shop, factory or construction site

> *The 2026 rules reach further than before - including sites and units outside municipal limits. Compliance is now a winter operating discipline, not a one-off.*

- Construction and demolition sites of 500 sq m or more must be registered on the state web portal and set up for remote dust monitoring.
- Dust-generating demolition and outdoor civil construction are restricted from 1 November 2026 to 31 January 2027, with a complete ban from 10 December 2026 to 20 January 2027 (urgent government and emergency works excepted).
- Major sites must run anti-smog guns or mist-suppression systems, cover stored material, and wash vehicle wheels before they leave.
- Industries in the 17 highly polluting categories face a particulate limit of 50 milligrams per normal cubic metre.
- Stone crushers must register on the monitoring portal and run video surveillance plus PM2.5/PM10 sensors.
- Offices can run at up to 50% physical attendance with staggered timings; plan rotas in advance so the transition on 1 November is smooth.

20. Your child's school: hybrid classes and what parents should do

> *From Stage III, classes up to Class V go hybrid by rule. From Stage IV, that extends to Classes VI-IX and XI. The choice to study online rests with you and your child, not the school.*

This is one of the clearest protections in the GRAP, and it is written to keep children out of the worst air without stopping their education. The rule applies in Delhi and in the districts of Gurugram, Faridabad, Ghaziabad and Gautam Buddh Nagar.

GRAP stage	Classes affected	Mode
Stage III	Nursery to Class V	Mandatory hybrid - physical and online together.
Stage IV	Classes VI-IX and XI	Mandatory hybrid - physical and online together.
Exam years	Classes X and XII	Generally remain in person, but verify with your school.

For parents of children with asthma

Keep a written action plan from your doctor and make sure the school has a copy and the child's reliever inhaler.

On 'Very Poor' and 'Severe' days, prefer the online option and keep outdoor play indoors.

A well-fitted N95 is the minimum for the commute; a loose mask offers little protection.

The CAQM has been explicit that where online study is available, the option to use it belongs to the student and the guardian - a school cannot compel physical attendance if a parent chooses the remote option on health grounds. In practice, during the January 2026 Stage IV spell, schools across the region shifted to online mode and revised timings, and government schools closed during the severe cold snap. So the practical steps are to know your school's online platform before the season, keep an N95 for the school commute, and watch the AQI before the morning run.

21. Your office and commute

> *The winter plan gives offices a 50% work-from-home option and staggered timings from 1 November to 31 January. GRAP's citizen charter separately urges anyone whose job allows it to work from home.*

For employers and employees, the headline is flexibility built into the calendar. Between 1 November 2026 and 31 January 2027, government and private offices can operate with no more than 50% physical attendance, with the rest working from home. Essential and emergency services - hospitals, public transport, power, water, sanitation, disaster management and pollution-control agencies - are exempt. Office timings are staggered: MCD offices 8:30 am to 5 pm, Delhi government offices 10 am to 6:30 pm.

The GRAP citizen charter also lists simple actions for everyone: use public transport and minimise personal vehicle use, choose less congested routes even if slightly longer, avoid idling, replace your vehicle's air filters on schedule, avoid dust-generating construction work from October to January, clean kitchen chimney filters, and avoid outdoor smoke-generating cooking or heating. Public transport is the single biggest lever you have - Delhi's bus fleet stands at 6,840 vehicles, including 5,088 electric buses, with last-mile connectivity at all 228 Metro stations.

- Metro plus e-rickshaw beats a solo car trip on both emissions and exposure.
- In your car, run the air-conditioning on 'recirculate' so you are not pulling in outside air.

- Avoid the worst windows: early morning and late evening are usually the dirtiest parts of a winter day.
- Carpooling cuts both your exposure and the load you add.

22. Working from home well in winter

> *If your role allows it, working from home is the single most effective way to cut your daily dose. Doing it well takes a few deliberate choices.*

- Set up in the room with the purifier, ideally not the one nearest a main road or a construction site.
- Keep the room sealed during high-pollution hours, and take a short airing break in the afternoon window.
- Take regular breaks and move - sitting still all day in a closed room is its own strain.
- If you must go in, use the 50% rota and staggered timings to travel outside the worst windows.
- Keep meetings short and check the AQI once or twice a day, not every hour.

23. What each stage means for each person

> *One table to answer the question everyone asks: what does this stage mean for me?*

Stage	On the road	School	Vulnerable people	Everyone
I - Poor (201-300)	Older diesel and out-of-state curbs begin	Normal	Cut outdoor effort	Mask optional; avoid exertion
II - Very Poor (301-400)	Higher parking; DG set curbs	Watch for notices	Stay in where possible	N95 outdoors; no outdoor exercise
III - Severe (401-450)	BS-III petrol and BS-IV diesel cars banned	Hybrid up to Class V	Remain indoors	No outdoor exercise; N95 for trips
IV - Severe+ (450+)	Trucks barred; odd-even possible	Hybrid to VI-IX and XI	Remain indoors	Stay in; avoid travel

24. Keeping indoor air clean at work

> *You cannot control the office air the way you control your home, but a few small moves reduce your dose.*

- Sit away from the main road-facing window where you can; the roadside is the dirtiest air in a building.
- If the office has a purifier or filtered HVAC, ask that it be serviced and the filters changed on schedule.
- Keep the building's windows shut on bad days, and avoid propping open doors that face traffic.
- Keep a personal N95 for the commute, and step out for breaks in the cleaner afternoon window.
- Raise ventilation and filter maintenance with facilities or HR - a clogged office filter affects everyone.

Part 3 - Protecting your family's health

25. Clean air at home: air purifiers done right

> *A purifier works, but only if it is a True HEPA unit sized to your room, run with the windows shut, and maintained. Most buyers get at least one of those wrong.*

A HEPA air purifier is the most effective way to cut the particles you breathe indoors. Reviews of the evidence consistently find that HEPA filtration reduces indoor PM2.5 and improves early markers of heart and lung health. But it is not a magic box: in a leaky room on the worst days, indoor air with the purifier running can still be dirty. The gains come from using it properly.

1. **Insist on True HEPA, graded H13 or H14.** 'HEPA-type', 'HEPA-like' and '99% HEPA' are marketing terms with no certified standard behind them and can leak fine particles. Look for the H-grade number in the specifications, not the headline.
2. **Size it to the room using CADR.** CADR (Clean Air Delivery Rate) is how much clean air the unit delivers per hour. A workable rule for Indian rooms: your minimum CADR in cubic metres per hour should be at least your room area in square feet multiplied by 0.75. In Delhi, size up by 20-30% for winter.
3. **Choose a unit with an activated carbon layer.** HEPA catches particles; carbon handles gases, odours and cooking fumes. A thick granulated carbon bed lasts far longer than a thin 'carbon coating'.
4. **Avoid ozone.** Ionisers and plasma stages can emit ozone, a lung irritant, and ozone generators do not work at safe levels. Prefer a purely mechanical HEPA-plus-carbon unit, or one that is CARB-certified or lets you switch the ioniser off.
5. **Run it sealed.** A purifier recirculates indoor air. With windows open, outdoor pollution comes in faster than a home unit can clean it. Keep windows and doors shut while it runs; briefly air the room between 12 pm and 4 pm, when the day's air is usually at its cleanest.
6. **Maintain it.** Clean the pre-filter monthly and replace the HEPA filter on schedule - Indian dust and pollution loads clog filters 1.5 to 2 times faster than manufacturer estimates assume. A clogged filter is an expensive fan.
7. **Prioritise the bedroom.** One good purifier in a closed bedroom, where you spend eight hours, beats a weak unit in every room.

Mark to look for	What it verifies
True HEPA H13 / H14	Filter grade - at least 99.95% of particles at 0.3 microns.
AHAM Verifide	The CADR figure was tested by an independent lab.
CARB certified	Ozone emissions under 0.050 ppm.

Three common myths, settled

'HEPA-type' is not HEPA. Without an H-grade number, you cannot trust the filtration.

'Kills 99.9% of viruses' needs ozone at unsafe levels. Skip it.

Indoor plants do almost nothing for air cleaning. They are for mood and decor, not for smog.

26. Choosing a purifier on a budget

> *You do not need the most expensive unit - you need the right one for one room. A correctly sized mid-range purifier beats an oversized cheap one and a tiny premium one.*

Air purifier prices in India range from a few thousand rupees to well over fifty thousand. The price gap is mostly about sensors, connectivity, noise and build - not about whether the unit can clean a room. For a Delhi winter, decide three things first: which room, how big, and what you can spend on replacement filters.

- Before buying, check the price and availability of the replacement filter. A purifier with no spare filters is useless after one season.
- If you can only afford one unit, put it in the room where the family sleeps - that is where the most exposure hours are.
- Do not judge by the number of filter stages. A real H13 HEPA plus a thick carbon layer beats a 'seven-stage' list of vague layers.
- India has no BEE star rating for purifiers and no BIS performance standard, so lean on global marks: True HEPA grade, AHAM Verifide CADR and CARB for ozone.

Budget	What you get	Best used for
Entry	A basic HEPA unit, often without a fine particle sensor or app control.	A single bedroom, run continuously on a fixed speed.
Mid	True HEPA with an activated carbon layer, a particle sensor and auto mode.	The main bedroom or a living room; the sweet spot for most families.
Premium	Higher CADR, larger carbon beds, quieter operation, better sensors.	Large living areas, or homes near a main road or construction site.

27. Home air monitors and sensors

> *You do not need a lab. A basic particle monitor tells you whether your purifier is winning, and a cheap CO2 monitor tells you when to air the room.*

- A consumer-grade PM2.5 monitor gives a live indoor reading, so you can see the purifier working - or not.
- Place the monitor away from the purifier's outlet, or you will read clean air that the rest of the room does not have.
- A CO2 monitor flags stuffiness; above roughly 1,000 ppm, it is time for a short airing.

- Sensors built into purifiers can misread Indian conditions, so treat a separate monitor as the honest referee.
- Remember these devices measure particles, not gases - a low reading does not mean the air is free of VOCs.

28. Masks that actually work

> *A well-fitted N95 or N99 is the only mask that meaningfully cuts what you inhale outdoors. Paper, cloth, handkerchiefs and scarves do not work.*

The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare's air pollution advisory is blunt on this: paper masks, handkerchiefs, scarves and cloth are not effective in poor-to-severe air. A certified N95 or N99, worn with a tight seal over the nose and mouth, is what filters the fine PM2.5 particles that matter.

- **Fit beats brand.** If you feel air leaking from the sides when you breathe out, smog is getting in the same way. The mask should sit snug over nose and chin, with no gaps.
- **Never pull it below your nose or mouth** - that removes almost all the protection.
- **Use it for short exposure.** A mask is not a licence for a long outdoor run on a 'Very Poor' day.
- **Replace it.** Discard a disposable N95 after a day of heavy use, or as soon as it becomes dirty or wet.
- **Children:** fit is hardest for small faces. Use the smallest certified size available and check the seal. If your child has asthma or another lung condition, ask your doctor before relying on a mask.

Mask type	Protects against PM2.5?	Notes
Cloth, scarf, handkerchief	No	Comfort only; the advisory says these are not effective.
Paper / surgical 'dust' mask	No	Traps large particles such as sawdust, not fine PM2.5.
N95 (well fitted)	Yes	Filters the fine fraction; fit is the deciding factor.
N99	Yes	Slightly higher filtration; useful for the most sensitive users.

29. The vulnerable ones: who needs extra care

> *Children under five, older adults, pregnant women and anyone with asthma, COPD or heart disease face the highest risk. For them, the AQI bands are not a guide - they are instructions.*

The health effects of air pollution depend on both the level and the duration of exposure, and some people are far more vulnerable. Short-term high exposure can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, wheezing and chest discomfort. Long-term exposure is linked to chronic respiratory and heart disease, and to lung cancer. The National Centre for Disease Control lists the people who must be protected first: children under five, older adults, pregnant women, people with pre-existing lung or heart conditions, and outdoor workers such as traffic police, street vendors and construction workers.

AQI band	General population	Vulnerable people
Moderate (101-200)	Reduce prolonged or strenuous outdoor effort.	Avoid prolonged or strenuous outdoor activity.
Poor (201-300)	Avoid outdoor physical exertion where possible; take water breaks; cover nose and mouth when out.	Avoid outdoor activity; if you must go out, wear a mask and take frequent water breaks.
Very Poor (301-400)	Avoid outdoor physical activity; do not add indoor pollution (burning, candles, tobacco); wear a close-fitting N95 or N99 outdoors.	Stay indoors and keep activity low; wear an N95 or N99 for any outdoor trip; eat well and drink water.
Severe (401-500)	Avoid outdoor activity; N95 or N99 outdoors; no indoor burning; drink plenty of water.	Remain indoors; step out only if urgent; always use a close-fitting N95 or N99 outside.

Two practical rules for a household with a vulnerable member. Keep their prescribed medicines stocked and never skip a dose - the advisory is explicit that people managing an existing illness should not miss medication. And treat breathlessness, giddiness, chest pain, chest tightness or eye irritation as reasons to see a doctor, not to wait.

30. Asthma and COPD: the smog-season plan

> *For anyone with asthma or COPD, winter is when attacks cluster. The plan is preparation, not reaction: medicines stocked, action plan shared, air clean at home.*

- Get a written action plan from your doctor before November, and keep the reliever inhaler with you at all times.
- Share the plan with your child's school, your workplace and, for elderly parents, with a neighbour or carer.
- Keep a spare inhaler and spacer at home and in your bag; do not let supplies run low during a bad spell.
- Run a HEPA purifier in the bedroom and keep it on overnight with the door and windows shut.
- Avoid outdoor exercise entirely on 'Very Poor' and 'Severe' days; move activity indoors.
- Watch for worsening cough, wheeze, breathlessness or reduced peak flow, and act on your plan early rather than waiting.
- Never stop or change a prescribed medicine because the air feels better - follow your doctor.

31. Heart and blood-pressure patients

> *Fine particles are a cardiovascular risk as much as a respiratory one. The same habits that protect the lungs also protect the heart.*

- Do not skip blood-pressure or heart medicines; pollution raises cardiovascular strain and consistent medication matters more, not less.
- Avoid strenuous outdoor activity on high-AQI days - the extra ventilation deepens exposure.
- Keep indoor air clean and avoid second-hand smoke, incense and indoor burning.
- Watch for chest discomfort, palpitations, unusual breathlessness or swelling, and seek care promptly.

- Keep a recent prescription and your doctor's contact number where the family can find them.

32. Pregnant women

> *Pregnancy is a period of higher vulnerability: the advisory notes that exposure during pregnancy may have consequences for the child in the womb.*

- Spend as much of the day as possible in a clean indoor space; run a purifier in the room where you rest and sleep.
- Avoid outdoor physical exertion, especially in the early morning and late evening.
- Wear a close-fitting N95 or N99 when you must step out, and keep trips short.
- Eat well and stay hydrated; keep up your routine antenatal checks.
- Avoid second-hand smoke and indoor burning at home.
- Discuss any breathing difficulty with your doctor rather than waiting.

33. Senior citizens

> *Older adults are more vulnerable to both the immediate and the long-term effects of air pollution, and often spend more time indoors where the air is not automatically clean.*

- Make sure the room an elderly family member uses most has a purifier and that windows are kept shut during bad hours.
- Avoid early-morning walks - shift them to the afternoon window when the air is usually cleaner.
- Keep a daily check-in habit so breathlessness or chest discomfort is noticed early.
- Keep medicines organised and topped up, with a clear list for any carer or family member.
- Avoid indoor burning, incense and strong fumes in their room.
- Have a plan for getting to a clinic quickly if breathing becomes difficult.

34. Outdoor workers

> *Traffic police, delivery riders, street vendors, construction workers, security guards and sanitation staff take the heaviest dose because they are outside all day. The health advisory names them as a vulnerable group.*

- A close-fitting N95 or N99 is the priority; cloth and paper coverings do not filter PM2.5.
- Take frequent water breaks and rotate tasks so long stretches of heavy exertion outdoors are avoided where possible.
- Where the workplace allows, use masks and schedule the most strenuous work for the cleaner afternoon window.
- Employers should provide masks, clean drinking water and a sheltered rest area, and consider shift rotation on 'Severe' days.
- Wash face and hands after the shift and change out of the day's outer clothing.
- Report symptoms such as persistent cough or breathlessness rather than working through them.

35. Children: play, sport and screens

> *Children breathe faster and take in more air per kilogram of body weight, so the same air hits them harder. Sport and outdoor play are where the dose spikes.*

- Shift outdoor play and sports practice indoors on 'Poor' days and above; school games on 'Severe' days should move inside.
- Avoid the school-run at the worst hour where you can; early morning is often the dirtiest window.
- Keep a well-fitted mask for the commute, and check it actually seals on a small face.
- Keep the child's room clean and ventilated at the right time, with the purifier running overnight.
- Do not use incense, mosquito coils or candles near children's sleeping areas.
- Watch for a persistent cough, wheeze or repeated colds and raise them with a doctor.

36. Pet owners

> *Dogs and cats take in the same fine particles, and pets with flat faces or existing heart or lung conditions are the most at risk.*

- Shorten walks on 'Very Poor' and 'Severe' days, and walk in the cleaner afternoon window.
- Avoid the roadside; choose a park or a quieter lane away from traffic.
- Wipe paws and coat after a walk so settled dust is not carried indoors.
- Keep indoor air clean and keep the purifier running; avoid indoor smoke of any kind.
- Watch for coughing, wheezing, lethargy or eye irritation, and consult a vet if they persist.
- Keep fresh water available; pets can be affected by dehydration and irritation just as people are.

37. Eyes, skin and hair in smog

> *Irritation of the eyes, nose and throat is one of the most common short-term effects of high pollution, and it is easy to manage.*

- Rinse eyes with clean water if they sting or water; avoid rubbing, which worsens irritation.
- Use lubricating eye drops if your doctor recommends them, especially if you wear contact lenses - consider switching to glasses on the worst days.
- Wash your face and hands after time outdoors, and shower before bed so particles are not carried onto your pillow.
- Keep skin moisturised; pollution and dry winter air together make skin drier and more reactive.
- Cover hair with a scarf or cap outdoors if it feels gritty, and wash it more often in the season.
- Seek medical advice for persistent eye redness, pain or discharge.

38. Home remedies: what helps, what is a myth

> *There is a lot of well-meaning advice about smog. Some of it helps a little; some of it is simply wrong and can cost you money or delay real protection.*

Claim	Verdict	Why
Indoor plants clean the air	Myth	Their measurable effect is negligible; a purifier is what works.
Steam inhalation clears the chest	Helps a little	Eases congestion and throat irritation; it does not remove pollution exposure.
A cloth mask is enough	Myth	Cloth does not filter PM2.5; only a fitted N95/N99 does.
Certain foods 'detox' the lungs	Overstated	A healthy diet supports general health, but no food undoes pollution damage.
A purifier lets you open windows	Myth	Open windows let pollution in faster than a home unit can clean.
Gargling and nasal rinse help	Helps a little	Can soothe an irritated throat and nose; use clean water and follow your doctor.

39. Your indoor air: the part you fully control

> *Your home is not automatically clean. Indian high-heat cooking, incense, candles and coils can push indoor PM2.5 above the outdoor level. Fixing the sources is as important as buying a purifier.*

- **Cooking is the biggest indoor source.** High-heat frying and tempering can spike indoor PM2.5 within minutes. Use a chimney or exhaust fan, keep a lid on where you can, and ventilate after cooking.
- **Cut combustion indoors.** Incense, candles, mosquito coils and tobacco smoke all add particles and gases. The health advisory specifically warns against indoor burning on bad-air days.
- **Clean without raising dust.** Wet mopping and damp dusting beat dry sweeping, which just stirs particles back up. If you vacuum, use one with a HEPA filter.
- **Seal and ventilate in balance.** Close windows during high-pollution hours and seal obvious gaps. Then air the house briefly between 12 pm and 4 pm, when outdoor levels are usually lowest, and resume.
- **Use your AC on recirculate** in the car and at home so you are not drawing in outside air.
- **Watch for stuffiness.** A closed home builds up carbon dioxide, which causes drowsiness and headaches. A cheap CO2 monitor tells you when it is time for a short airing.

40. Preparing your home, room by room

> *Clean air is won room by room. The bedroom matters most, then the room where you cook and gather.*

Room	What to do
Bedroom	Purifier on overnight, windows and door shut, no incense or coils, wash bedding often.
Living room	Purifier if you have a second unit; keep windows shut in the worst hours; HEPA vacuum or wet mop.
Kitchen	Chimney or exhaust fan always on while cooking; lid on where possible; ventilate afterwards.
Windows and balcony	Seal gaps; keep shut during high-pollution hours; brief afternoon airing only.
Entryway	A mat and a place to leave outer shoes and jackets so dust is not walked in.

41. Sealing your home: a practical checklist

> *You cannot seal a home completely, and you should not try. You can cut the leaks that let the most pollution in.*

- Close windows and balcony doors during the worst hours - early morning and late evening.
- Fit draught strips or simple tape on gaps around window frames and doors where you feel a draught.
- Keep the door to the room with the purifier shut, so the clean air is not diluted.
- Use exhaust fans in the kitchen and bathroom briefly, then close them - a running exhaust pulls outside air in.
- Choose one or two airing slots in the afternoon, keep them short (5-10 minutes), then seal again.
- Do not block vents entirely; some ventilation is needed to avoid a build-up of CO2 and moisture.

42. Cooking without filling the house with smoke

> *The kitchen is the biggest source of indoor particles in most Indian homes. A chimney and a few habits cut it sharply.*

- Run the chimney or exhaust fan whenever the stove is on - and for a few minutes after.
- Keep a lid on where you can; frying and tempering at high heat produce the most particles.
- Cook the heaviest, smokiest dishes when the purifier is on high and the kitchen door is shut.
- Clean the chimney filters regularly; a clogged filter stops doing its job.
- Avoid burning anything indoors - no incense or candles during cooking, especially near children.
- If you have no chimney, open the kitchen window briefly during cooking and ventilate afterwards.

43. Maintaining your purifier: a season calendar

> *A purifier is only as good as its maintenance. Five minutes a month keeps it working through the season.*

When	Do this
Monthly	Clean or vacuum the pre-filter; check the airflow with your hand.
Every 2-3 months in season	Inspect the HEPA filter; replace it if airflow has dropped or it looks grey.
When odours return	The carbon layer is spent - replace it.
Start of season	Order spare filters before demand peaks.
End of season	Clean the unit, store filters dry, note the model number for reordering.

44. Air quality and sleep

> *You spend a third of your life asleep, and that is when the purifier earns its money. A few choices protect those hours.*

- Run the purifier in the bedroom overnight with the door and windows shut.

- Choose a unit with a quiet sleep mode; noise keeps people awake, and an unused purifier protects no one.
- Keep the bedroom free of incense, candles and mosquito coils.
- Wash bedding and pillow covers often; they collect the fine dust that settles overnight.
- If you wake with a dry throat or a blocked nose, air the room briefly in the morning and check the purifier's placement.

45. If you have a newborn at home

> *Infants are among the most vulnerable to air pollution. The first months, in the smog season, deserve a little extra planning.*

- Keep the baby's room as the cleanest in the house: purifier running, windows shut, no incense or candles.
- Avoid taking a newborn outdoors on 'Very Poor' and 'Severe' days except for essential visits.
- If you must go out, keep the trip short and cover the pram against dust and grit.
- Do not use mosquito coils or incense near a baby's sleeping area; use nets and screens instead.
- Watch for feeding difficulty, unusual breathing or irritability, and see a paediatrician promptly.
- Breastfeeding supports the baby's immune system; keep up routine paediatric visits.

46. Managing asthma at school: a letter for teachers

> *A short written note to your child's school can make a real difference on a bad-air day.*

- Name your child's condition and the medicines they carry, and where the reliever inhaler is kept.
- State the trigger conditions - for example, air quality in the 'Poor' band or worse.
- Ask the school to allow the child to sit out outdoor games and sports on those days.
- Ask to be informed if the child has a cough, wheeze or breathlessness during the day.
- Request that the child be allowed to use the online or hybrid option when a GRAP stage is in force.
- Give the school your and your doctor's contact numbers, and keep them updated.

47. Your smog-season health routine

> *Small, consistent habits reduce your exposure and help your body cope. None of them replaces a purifier or a mask - they work alongside them.*

- **Hydrate.** Drink water through the day; warm fluids help soothe a dry, irritated throat.
- **Eat simply and well.** A normal diet rich in fruit and vegetables supports general health. No single food 'cleans' your lungs - be wary of any product that claims to.
- **Move your workout indoors** on Poor days and above. Early-morning outdoor exercise is the worst choice of the winter, because that is when the air is often thickest.
- **Use steam for congestion** if it helps you, taking care with hot water and children.

- **Do not smoke, and avoid second-hand smoke.** Smoking multiplies the harm of polluted air.
- **Know your symptoms.** Persistent cough, wheeze, chest tightness, breathlessness or eye irritation that does not settle is a reason to see a doctor.

48. If you must be outdoors: minimising your dose

> *Sometimes you have no choice. When you do go out, the goal is to cut the time, the effort and the exposure at once.*

- Wear a close-fitting N95 or N99, and check the seal before you leave.
- Go in the afternoon window (roughly 12 pm to 4 pm), when the air is usually cleanest.
- Walk on quieter, less trafficked routes; the roadside is the worst place to be.
- Reduce effort - a slow walk beats a brisk one, because harder breathing draws in more air.
- Keep trips short and combine errands into one outing.
- On return, wash your face and hands and change out of your outer layer.

49. What to ask your doctor

> *If someone at home is in a high-risk group, a short conversation before winter is worth more than any gadget.*

- What is my (or my child's, or my parent's) personal action plan for high-pollution days?
- Should I keep a reliever inhaler or spare medicine at home, and how do I use it?
- Which symptoms should make me seek care immediately?
- Are my current medicines safe to continue through the season without change?
- Do you recommend a mask for this person, and which type?
- Is there anything in my home - cooking, heating, incense - that I should change?

50. Staying fit in winter smog

> *Do not give up exercise - move it indoors. Outdoor workouts on bad days do more harm than the fitness is worth.*

- Shift runs, walks and cycling indoors on 'Poor' days and above; a home workout, gym or indoor pool works.
- If you must train outside, go in the afternoon window and keep the effort light; hard breathing draws in more pollution.
- Watch indoor air quality while you exercise - a workout in a closed room without ventilation raises CO2.
- Keep hydration up and warm up properly; cold, dry air plus pollution is hard on the airways.
- If you have asthma or a heart condition, treat high-AQI days as rest days and follow your doctor's advice.

Part 4 - Act

51. Diwali 2026 and firecrackers

> *Diwali falls on Sunday 8 November 2026, with Dhanteras on Friday 6 November. The Supreme Court has ruled out a blanket ban but also ruled out all-day bursting, leaving the exact hours to be settled through the CAQM and further orders.*

Firecrackers are the one seasonal spike that is entirely within our control, and this year the legal position has been moving through the courts in the run-up to the festival. On 30 September 2026, a Supreme Court bench said it would not impose a total ban - citing sentiment - but would also not allow fireworks through the day, pointing to the harm to children, the elderly and the sick. On 12 October, in the Delhi-NCR air pollution case, the court left the existing ban in place and asked the CAQM to give its view. A further hearing was set for 15 October, with the assessment of barium-based 'green' crackers still pending.

The Centre told the court that laboratory tests by CSIR-NEERI on new-generation green crackers containing barium showed a 45 to 60 percent reduction in PM10 emissions. If green crackers are permitted this year, expect them to be limited to specified hours and sold through designated sellers - the pattern used in October 2025, when certified green crackers were allowed over a few days in fixed slots.

The practical plan for Diwali week

Check the CAQM and Delhi government order in the week of Diwali - the position can change up to the last few days.

If green crackers are allowed, use them only within the notified hours; the safest celebration is diyas and lights.

The morning after Diwali is typically the year's worst AQI day. Plan to stay in, with the purifier on high and windows shut.

If anyone at home has asthma or a heart condition, keep medicines to hand and avoid going out that morning.

52. How to report pollution and get help

> *You have official tools to check the air and to report pollution where you live. Using them is part of the fix, and complaints are tracked to resolution.*

A useful habit is to save the CAQM page and the CPCB app on your phone at the start of the season. When you see open burning, illegal dumping or a dust-belching site, report it with a photo - the Green Delhi app is built for exactly that, and the CAQM has instructed agencies to act quickly on complaints.

Tool	What it does
SAMEER app (CPCB)	Check live AQI and report polluting activities. Recommended by CAQM for citizens.
Green Delhi app (DPCC)	Report pollution-causing instances; 27 civic agencies on one platform, with photo, video and audio, and time-bound resolution.
311 app / MCD 311	Civic complaints, including garbage and local issues. Delhi's 311 helpline also takes pollution reports.
Green Delhi public portal	Send suggestions to the Delhi government on reducing air pollution.

Tool	What it does
CAQM website (caqm.nic.in)	The authoritative source for the current GRAP stage and all directions and orders.
CPCB website / app	Daily and real-time AQI bulletins across the network.

53. The week-by-week winter calendar

A single page you can pin up. It turns the whole season into a few dated actions.

When	Do this
Now (late October)	Service the purifier and order spare filters. Check the car's PUC, BS stage and age. Stock N95/N99 masks. Save the CAQM, CPCB, SAMEER and Green Delhi apps. Refill prescriptions.
1 November	The winter plan starts: out-of-state sub-BS-VI vehicles are barred; construction is restricted; 50% WFH and staggered timings begin. Note your office's rota.
Diwali week (early Nov)	Check the firecracker order; plan Diwali night and the morning after indoors, purifier on high.
Through November	Track the daily GRAP stage. Expect Stage I and II to come and go. Keep outdoor exercise in the afternoon window.
10 December - 20 January	The full construction ban. Historically the worst air. Run the purifier on high, minimise travel, keep medicines stocked.
December - January	Stage III and IV most likely. Watch for hybrid-school notices and possible odd-even. Prefer the online school option on the worst days.
February	The plan eases, but bad spells continue to the end of the month. Keep checking the stage.

54. Your smog-season action plan

Two lists do most of the work: a one-time preparation checklist before November, and a two-minute daily routine once the season starts.

- **Before the season:** check your car (fuel type, BS stage, age, PUC); decide your child's hybrid-school plan; service the purifier and buy spare filters; stock N95/N99 masks; refill prescriptions; save the apps.
- **Every day in season:** check the AQI and the GRAP stage; decide mask, purifier speed, school mode and travel mode; keep windows shut in the worst hours and air the house in the afternoon; avoid indoor burning.
- **Emergency kit:** two or three spare N95/N99 masks; a spare purifier filter or the model number; prescribed medicines and a reliever inhaler with a written plan; a thermometer and your doctor's number.

AQI band	Mask outside	Purifier	Outdoor exercise	School
Moderate (101-200)	Optional	Normal	Reduce intensity	In person
Poor (201-300)	Recommended	Normal - high in the evening	Avoid	In person
Very Poor (301-400)	N95/N99 required	High	None	In person (watch notices)
Severe (401-500)	N95/N99, short trips only	High, sealed room	None	Hybrid from Stage III (up to Class V)
Severe Plus (450+)	Avoid going out	High, sealed room	None	Hybrid to VI-IX and XI

55. The cost of clean air: what to budget

A workable clean-air setup does not have to be expensive. Prioritise one good purifier and a stock of masks.

Item	Priority	Rough approach
One True HEPA purifier (bedroom)	Highest	Mid-range, sized by CADR; check the spare filter price before buying.
Spare HEPA filters	High	One spare before the season; Indian loads clog filters fast.
N95/N99 masks for the family	High	A few per person; replace after heavy use or when dirty.
CO2 monitor	Optional	Cheap; tells you when the room needs a short airing.
PM2.5 monitor	Optional	Useful, but not essential if the purifier is well chosen.

56. Ten myths about Delhi's air

There is more misinformation about smog than about almost any other seasonal topic. Here are the ten claims worth ignoring.

Myth	Truth
The AQI is the same everywhere in the city	It varies street by street; check your local station.
A purifier lets you keep windows open	Open windows let pollution in faster than a unit can clean.
Cloth masks are good enough	They do not filter PM2.5; only a fitted N95/N99 works.
Plants clean your air	Negligible effect; a purifier is what works.
Any HEPA filter is fine	Only True HEPA H13/H14 is certified; 'HEPA-type' is not.
Stubble burning is the whole problem	It is one source; transport, dust and secondary particles matter more.
Only rain clears the air	Wind clears it too - and so does cutting your own exposure.
You can exercise outdoors on a 'Poor' day	'Poor' is when sensitive people should already cut outdoor effort.
A purifier removes gases as well	Only if it has a real activated carbon layer; HEPA is particles only.
There is nothing you can do	Your indoor air, your commute and your vehicle are all in your control.

57. Smog and your mental health

> *The grey, closed-in months wear people down, and being told to stay indoors can feel isolating. Naming that is part of managing it.*

Living through weeks of hazardous air is genuinely stressful. People describe a low, boxed-in feeling, difficulty sleeping, and a sense of helplessness when the sky stays grey for days. That reaction is normal, and it is worth planning for as carefully as you plan for the physical risks.

- Keep routines: fixed sleep and meal times, and indoor movement such as stretching or a short workout, help mood and sleep.
- Stay connected - call family and friends, and keep social plans indoors rather than cancelling them altogether.
- Get daylight where you can, ideally in the cleaner afternoon window, and keep indoor spaces bright.
- Limit doom-scrolling on AQI numbers; check once or twice a day, then close the app.
- If low mood, anxiety or poor sleep persists, talk to a doctor or a mental-health professional. It is a normal thing to seek help for.

58. What last winter actually looked like

> *A data snapshot of winter 2025-26 shows how fast the season turns - and why early preparation pays.*

The lesson is simple: the season is long, and the worst days cluster in December and January. Preparing in October means the peak months cost you far less - in money, in comfort and in health.

Period	What happened
13 October 2025	The last 'Moderate' day before a long bad stretch began.
October 2025 to February 2026	26 'Poor' days, 66 'Very Poor' days and 10 'Severe' days.
14 December 2025	Peak reading of AQI 461 - the worst day of the season.
January 2026	GRAP Stage III and Stage IV invoked; schools shifted to hybrid and online.
February 2026	Stages lifted progressively as conditions eased.

59. Frequently asked questions

> *The questions families ask most, answered plainly.*

Is the AQI the same across Delhi? No. Readings vary street by street and by time of day. The city figure is an average; your local station on the CPCB or SAMEER app is a better guide for your neighbourhood.

Will a purifier let me open my windows? Not on bad days. A purifier cleans recirculated indoor air; open windows let pollution in faster than it can clean. Air the house only briefly, in the afternoon.

Do cloth masks or scarves help? No. The health advisory says paper, cloth, handkerchiefs and scarves are not effective against PM2.5. Only a close-fitting N95 or N99 works.

Can I drive my diesel car this winter? It depends on the GRAP stage and your vehicle's BS rating. BS-VI diesel is allowed through Stage III; BS-IV diesel four-wheelers are banned at Stage III, and all

non-essential diesel is banned at Stage IV.

My car is registered outside Delhi. Can I bring it in? If it meets BS-VI, yes. If it is below BS-VI, it cannot enter Delhi from 1 November 2026 to 31 January 2027. CNG and electric vehicles are exempt.

What is the odd-even scheme and is it running? Odd-even restricts cars by number plate on alternate days. It is not in continuous operation in 2026, but it remains available under GRAP Stage IV, typically with about 48 hours' notice.

Should my child go to school on a 'Severe' day? From Stage III, classes up to Class V must be offered in hybrid mode, and from Stage IV that extends to Classes VI-IX and XI. The choice to study online belongs to you and your child.

Do indoor plants clean the air? Effectively no. Their air-cleaning effect is negligible. Keep them for how they look, not for your lungs.

Are 'green' crackers safe? They are less polluting than conventional crackers, and NEERI tests on new-generation barium-based green crackers showed 45 to 60 percent lower PM10 emissions. Less polluting is not the same as harmless, and their use is still subject to time and sale restrictions.

When is the air worst? Early morning and late evening, and during the coldest, stillest days of December and January. The afternoon, roughly 12 pm to 4 pm, is usually the cleanest window.

Will this winter be better than last year? Nobody can promise that. September 2026 was Delhi's cleanest September in five years, but early October was already worse than the year before. The new framework acts earlier; whether it works depends on enforcement and on the weather.

Where do I get the official word? The CAQM website for GRAP stages and orders, the CPCB app and website for the AQI, and the Delhi government for its winter plan updates. Always trust the latest official order over any summary - including this one.

60. Your one-page cheat sheet

> *Print this page. If you remember nothing else from this playbook, remember these.*

- Check the AQI and the GRAP stage every morning.
- At 201, cut outdoor effort; at 301, mask up outdoors; at 401, expect car bans and hybrid school; at 450, stay in.
- One True HEPA purifier, correctly sized, in the bedroom, with windows shut.
- A close-fitting N95 or N99 outdoors on 'Very Poor' and 'Severe' days.
- No indoor burning: incense, candles, coils, tobacco.
- Keep the vulnerable person's medicines stocked and their action plan shared.
- Air the house briefly in the afternoon, then seal it again.
- Report pollution you see: the Green Delhi app, the SAMEER app, or 311.
- Confirm the latest rules on caqm.nic.in - dates and stages change.

61. A day during a 'Severe' spell: a walk-through

> *It helps to rehearse the worst day. Here is how a Stage III or IV day plays out, and what to do at each point.*

Morning: you wake to AQI 430 and a CAQM Stage III order. Your child's school, if it runs up to Class V, is offering hybrid classes - you choose online. The car stays parked because it is a BS-IV diesel. You check that your parent's medicines are stocked.

Commute: you take the Metro and an e-rickshaw. You wear a fitted N95 for the walk to the station and keep it on in the e-rickshaw. The purifier is left running in the bedroom.

Day: windows stay shut. The kitchen chimney runs through lunch. You work from home, in the room with the purifier. No incense or candles.

Afternoon: you take a five-minute airing break around 2 pm, then seal the room again. Any outdoor errand that can wait, waits.

Evening: the purifier goes to high. You cook early, ventilate the kitchen briefly, and keep the bedroom door shut. You check tomorrow's forecast - a change of wind could lift the stage.

Night: the purifier runs on sleep mode in the bedroom. Medicines and an inhaler are within reach. You do not check the AQI again until morning.

62. Travelling out of the city this winter

> *If you can, the cleanest move in the worst weeks is to be somewhere else. If you cannot, plan the trip to minimise exposure.*

- If you have family in a cleaner city or the hills, consider moving the most vulnerable member there for the worst weeks of December and January.
- Travel in the cleaner afternoon window where you can, and wear a mask in transit.
- In the car, keep the air-conditioning on recirculate; do not leave windows open on the highway through polluted stretches.
- At your destination, check the local AQI - the same six categories and the same habits apply.
- If you are leaving home, leave spare filters and medicines ready for your return.

63. Your winter essentials: the family kit

> *One box, checked once, covers the whole season.*

- Two or three spare N95 or N99 masks per person.
- A spare HEPA filter, or the purifier model number saved for a fast reorder.
- Prescribed medicines and a reliever inhaler, with a written action plan.
- A thermometer and your doctor's number.
- A cheap CO2 monitor (optional) and, if you have one, a PM2.5 monitor.
- A note of the CAQM stage link and the reporting apps, pinned where the family can see it.

64. Glossary

The terms used in this playbook and in the official orders, in plain language.

Term	Meaning
AQI	Air Quality Index - a 0 to 500 number summarising air quality; the worst pollutant sets the value.
PM2.5 / PM10	Particles up to 2.5 and 10 microns wide. PM2.5 travels deepest into the lungs.
CAQM	Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR and Adjoining Areas - the body that runs GRAP.
GRAP	Graded Response Action Plan - the four-stage escalator of restrictions, from AQI 201 to above 450.
C&D;	Construction and demolition - the activity that produces dust and is restricted each winter.
DG set	Diesel generator set - its use is restricted from Stage I onwards.
PUCC	Pollution Under Control Certificate - mandatory for fuel and for driving.
BS-VI	Bharat Stage VI - the emission standard. Out-of-state sub-BS-VI vehicles are barred from Delhi in winter.
Hybrid class	School teaching in physical and online mode together; the option to attend online is the family's.
Odd-even	A scheme restricting cars by number plate on alternate days; available under GRAP Stage IV.
CADR	Clean Air Delivery Rate - the volume of filtered air a purifier delivers per hour.
HEPA	High Efficiency Particulate Air filter; True HEPA H13/H14 catches at least 99.95% of 0.3-micron particles.

65. Sources

This playbook was compiled from the following official and primary sources, checked in October 2026. Where rules or dates can change, verify against the latest order.

- Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) - Graded Response Action Plan for NCR, Revision 29.09.2026 (Direction No. 104), and CAQM directions 98, 100, 101 and 103 (2026). caqm.nic.in
- Delhi government - Winter Action Plan 2026-27 / Proactive Winter Air Quality Management Framework, announced 28 September 2026.
- Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) - National Air Quality Index: categories, health breakpoints and health impacts. airquality.cpcb.gov.in
- Ministry of Health and Family Welfare / NCDC and NHSRC - Air Pollution and Health advisories (AQI bands, masks, purifiers, vulnerable groups).
- World Health Organization - WHO global air quality guidelines (2021) and the WHO SEARO Advisory for Air Pollution.
- Supreme Court of India - proceedings on firecrackers in Delhi-NCR, September and October 2026.
- Press reporting from The Hindu, Indian Express, India Today, ThePrint and JanVayu for the winter plan, GRAP revision and enforcement figures.

Prices, dates and rules change. Always confirm the latest position on caqm.nic.in and cpcb.nic.in before you act. This guide is general information and is not medical advice.